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WEATHER HIT
A farmer assesses his damaged wheat crop, Amritsar, Punjab, Apr. 8

▶ PUNJAB

A BALEFUL BAISAKHI

Erratic weather flattens harvest-ready wheat in Punjab and across the North. Farm incomes, food prices, monetary policy, rural demand—all are at risk

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

ON APRIL 13, THE *DHOL* BEATS ringing in Baisakhi must have sounded hollow to Gurpreet Singh, as he stood in silence at the edge of his field in a village near Arif Ke in Ferozepur. This is usually the day when months of labour ripens to a golden hue. This year, his wheat lay flattened, beaten down by unseasonal rains, gust and hail—arriving at the precise moment when the rabi crop was awaiting cutting. "The harvest was ready," says the 48-year-old farmer, holding damp, discoloured grain. "Just a few more days, and I would have had my season's earnings."

Across north India, Baisakhi has brought not abundance but a reminder of vulnerability. Erratic weather disrupted the agricultural cycle at its most critical point. By central estimates, over 250,000 hectares of rabi crops stand affected, with wheat bearing the brunt, along with *chana* (gram) and other crops. In key regions, localised losses go up to 80 per cent; even less affected areas suffered quality deterioration.